Point-and-shoot cameras

Olympus XZ-1
Price: ₹25,999

It was a busy year for the point-and-shoot digital camera segment, with smartphones sporting very competent imaging capabilities, digital cameras had to up their game to justify their existence. The usual megapixel race was replaced by the race for newer, smarter sensors with the latest tech like back-illuminated CMOS sensors for better low-light capability, faster processors for speedy overall operation and better lenses to allow for more flexibility and creativity when filming stills and videos. Digital video recording in cameras almost took the same stage as still photography with most cameras sporting full HD – 1080p video capture and some even offering high-speed video capture at 60 fps. The industry focused on improving upon areas like low-light shooting, faster and smarter auto-focusing and offering more optical zoom in compact form factors. The travel-zoom category saw the most action with cameras offering as much as 18x of optical zoom along with better quality sensors for low-light shooting, all compressed in a compact, pocketable form factor.

Apart from the basics, manufacturers also included new features such as GPS, Wi-Fi connectivity, 3D capture and touchscreen-based models to create unique differentiators in a very crowded marketplace.

The LCD screens saw a significant jump in resolution, size and technology. The next wave of point-and-shoot cameras in 2012 are expected to inch closer to professional quality output by using larger sensors, for capturing more detail and better high-ISO performance. Cameras are also expected to drastically improve in the speed department, offering reduced shutter-lag and increased focus speed. The back-illuminated CMOS sensors are expected to almost become a norm with even the most basic cameras boasting improved low-light performance.

Canon Powershot S95
Price: ₹21,995

Zero1 Winner
Olympus XZ-1

The XZ-1 is by far the best point-and-shoot camera that we tested in 2011. The image quality of the XZ-1 is almost in the same league as the larger and more expensive micro 4/3rd cameras. Olympus has opted for a killer combination of a larger sensor and fast F1.8 iZuiko lens for the XZ-1, resulting in super-sharp images with lots of detail and punchy colors. The Olympus XZ-1 scored 85 per cent in our performance test for exceptional performance in low-light shooting and its unique ability to offer very good control over depth of field, just like the dSLRs. While the image quality itself is sufficient enough to take it to the top spot, the rugged construction, brilliant 610K OLED screen, HD video capture, intuitive control ring around the lens and excellent art filters make Olympus XZ-1 the most desirable point-and-shoot camera today.

Worthy Mention
Canon Powershot S95

The Canon Powershot S95 is the only camera that came close to the Olympus ZX-1, thanks to the F2.0 lens and a larger 1/1.7” sensor inside the camera. The Canon S95 scored 80 per cent in our performance tests. It offers HD video recording at 24 fps. Apart from the image quality and speedy overall operation, the Canon Powershot S95 also excels in portability, being extremely easy to carry along.

Back illuminated Sensor (BSI or BI)
A back-illuminated sensor, also known as backside illumination (BSI or BI) sensor, is a type of digital image sensor that uses a novel arrangement of the imaging elements to increase the amount of light captured and thereby improve on low-light performance.

HDR mode in cameras
High Dynamic Range (HDR) mode is useful in obtaining accurate exposure in extreme shooting conditions where it's difficult to obtain accurate exposure in the lightest and the darkest areas of the frame. It's done so by rapidly capturing multiple exposures of the same scene and combining it into a single image.